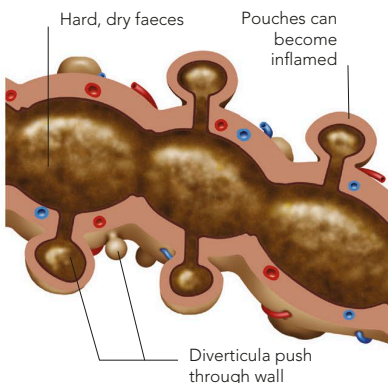
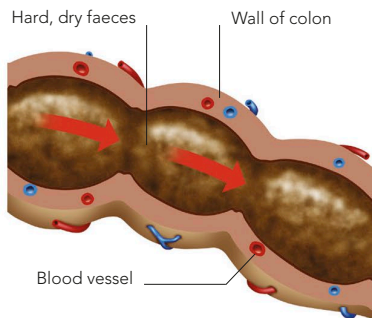


DIVERTICULAR DISEASE

In diverticular disease, patches of the colon wall bulge outward into pouches called diverticula. Most people with diverticular disease are aged over 50 and have eaten a low-fibre diet for many years, with consequent straining as they pass hard stools. The problem becomes more common with increasing age. The lowest part of the colon, known as the sigmoid colon (see p.227), is most commonly affected, but the whole of the colon can be involved. About 95 per cent of people with diverticular disease do not show symptoms, but some people have abdominal pain and irregular bowel habits. In diverticulitis, the pouches become inflamed, causing severe pain, fever, and constipation. The pain is often in the lower left abdomen, and may fade after passing gas or stools.

1 HARD FAECES

Soft, bulky faeces are able to pass easily along the colon. If faeces are hard and dry, usually due to lack of fibre or "roughage" in the diet, the contractions of the smooth muscle layers of the colon must increase in force, putting pressure on the walls of the colon.

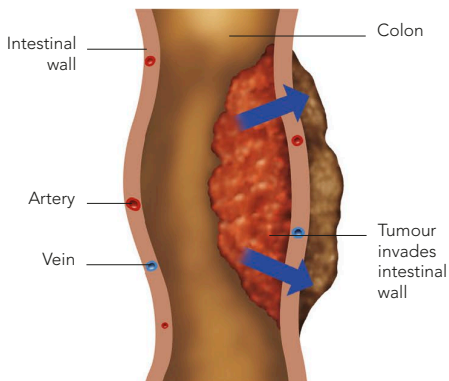


2 POUCHES FORM

Eventually, the increased pressure pushes small areas of colon lining through points of weakness in the muscle of the wall, often near a blood vessel. The pea- to grape-sized pouches that form easily trap bacteria and may become inflamed.

COLORECTAL CANCER

Cancer of the colon, rectum, or both, is one of the most common cancers in the industrialized world. Risk factors include family history and ageing. A malignant tumour in the intestinal wall can start as a polyp in the lining. A high-fat, low-fibre diet, excess alcohol, lack of exercise, and obesity can make this cancer more likely to develop. Symptoms are a change in bowel habits and stool consistency, abdominal pain, loss of appetite, faecal blood, and a sensation of not fully emptying the bowels. Colorectal cancer can be detected by screening programmes, such as faecal tests for blood and endoscopic examination (sigmoidoscopy). If it is detected and treated early, the chances of survival for five years or longer are high.



COLONIC TUMOUR

Over time, malignant tumours grow and invade the intestinal wall, from where the cancer can spread to other parts of the body via the bloodstream.